

The story I tell about a decision

Unit 04 · The Stories We Tell Ourselves · Long-form personal essay

30 SEPTEMBER 2026 · 14:32 UTC

DRAFT 1 · 214 WORDS

WRITING SUPPORT: NOT RECORDED

01 The task

Choose a decision you often explain to other people. Tell the story you usually tell, then examine it: what does it select, what does it leave out, and what does the story do for you? Use evidence from the unit reading where it helps your argument.

TARGET: 800–1,200 WORDS

02 Your text · Draft 1

214 WORDS

When I left São Paulo I believed I was leaving a place. It took me years to understand that I was leaving a version of myself that only existed in that city, in that language, among those people.

The story I tell about that move is tidy. I say I was ready, that the decision was rational, that the job made sense. It goes without saying that this story is not false. But it is selected: it keeps the reasons that make me look deliberate and quietly drops the ones that make me look afraid.

Memory researchers would say this is not lying but reconstruction. Every time I retell the move, I strengthen the parts that fit the person I want to be. The question, then, is not whether my story is true, but what it is doing for me.

03 What already works

- A clear governing claim that arrives at the right moment ("not whether my story is true, but what it is doing for me").
- Honest, specific self-observation instead of generalisation.
- Good use of contrast to structure the paragraph about selection.

04 Start here · priorities for Draft 2

1. Develop what the story does for you, with one concrete moment that contradicts the tidy version.
2. Decide whether the closing question is your conclusion or your turning point, and restructure the ending around it.
3. Replace the two ready-made phrases with your own wording.

05 Diagnosis by dimension

Task achievement

You tell the usual story and begin to examine it, but the essay stops before developing what the story leaves out.

WORKING

- Addresses the first two parts of the prompt.

TO SHARPEN

- Develop the third part: what the story does for you, with one concrete example.

Argument development

The claim is strong; the support is still thin.

WORKING

- The reconstruction idea connects well to the unit reading.

TO SHARPEN

- Add one moment that contradicts the tidy version.

Organisation & coherence

Three clear moves; the ending opens a question rather than closing the essay.

TO SHARPEN

- Decide whether the final question is your conclusion or your turning point.

Grammatical accuracy & range

Accurate and varied, including cleft and contrastive structures.

WORKING

- "It took me years to understand that..."

Lexical precision & range

Precise overall; one or two fixed phrases weaken the voice.

WORKING

- "selected", "quietly drops"

TO SHARPEN

- Replace ready-made phrases with your own wording.

Register & tone

The reflective, personal register suits this task.

Hedging & stance

Calibrated: you distinguish "not false" from "selected".

06 Specific observations

3 EXCERPTS

Each excerpt is classified. Only **Error** means something is wrong; the others are about naturalness, register, a valid choice, or language worth keeping.

STRONG LANGUAGE

it keeps the reasons that make me look deliberate and quietly drops the ones that make me look afraid

WHAT HAPPENS

A balanced parallel structure that carries the argument.

EFFECT

The reader sees the mechanism of selection, not just the claim.

HOW TO REVISE

Keep it; consider making it the pivot of the essay.

AWKWARD · LESS NATURAL

It goes without saying that this story is not false.

WHAT HAPPENS	A fixed phrase that says the opposite of what it does: you do say it.
EFFECT	Slightly weakens an otherwise personal voice.
HOW TO REVISE	State the concession directly and let it stand on its own.

STYLE CHOICE

The question, then, is not whether

WHAT HAPPENS	Interrupting "then" slows the sentence deliberately.
EFFECT	Signals a turn in the argument.
HOW TO REVISE	No change needed.

07 Questions for you as the writer

- Which reason did the tidy story drop, exactly?
- Who is the story usually told to, and does that change what it selects?

08 Suggested Error Log entries

YOURS	It goes without saying that...
CORRECT	Admittedly, ...
RULE	Fixed phrase used for a concession you then make explicitly.
NEW EXAMPLE	<i>Admittedly, the decision made financial sense.</i>

09 Estimated level of this piece

C1 · Controlled complex syntax and a clear line of argument; occasional formulaic phrasing.

An AI estimate for this one text, not a measure of your English.

Model gpt-5.6-sol · prompt main-write-v1

Feedback diagnoses; it never rewrites your text. Exporting makes no AI call.